

Purpose: To help us understand the grand scope of the plan of salvation and encourage us to live accordingly.

1. The plan of salvation is “one of heaven’s best gifts to mankind.”

Heavenly Father’s plan of salvation (Alma 24:14) is also known as the plan of happiness (Alma 42:8, 16); or the plan of redemption (Jacob 6:8; Alma 12:25-33); or the plan of restoration (Alma 41:2); or the plan of mercy (Alma 41:2).

†1. The Prophet Joseph Smith †2. President Boyd K. Packer

Videos: [The Plan of Salvation](#) (10:39) [Plan of Salvation – We’re Still a Family](#) (4:47) [Our Eternal Life](#) (3:46)

What can we do to give the plan of salvation “our strict attention”?

†3. Pres. Henry B. Eyring †4. Pres. Boyd K. Packer †5. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

†6. Elder M. Russell Ballard †7. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

2. Premortal life.

One “significant blessing of the Restoration is our increased knowledge of our premortal life. This knowledge helps us understand life’s purpose and our part in God’s plan of salvation.” (*Lesson Manual*)

• D&C 76:24; 93:29. “begotten sons and daughters unto God.” “Man was also in the beginning with God.”

What parts of “the plan” were presented at the Grand Council? (2 Ne. 2:24-26; Alma 34:8-9; Abr. 3:24-25)

• Moses 4:2; D&C 76:40-42. Of this plan, Jesus said, “Father, thy will be done, and the glory be thine forever.”

The “Atonement of Jesus Christ makes the plan of salvation possible. The Savior is the central figure in God’s plan for our Salvation.” (*Lesson Manual*)

• Moses 4:1, 3-4; D&C 29:36-38; Abr. 3:26. Why is it important for us to know about Satan and his followers?

• Job 38:4-7. “When the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy?”

• D&C 138:55-56; Abraham 3:22-23. “Heavenly Father chose and foreordained noble spirits” to do His work on earth.

3. Mortal life.

When “we accepted Heavenly Father’s plan in our premortal life, we kept our ‘first estate.’ Because of our faithfulness, we were given the opportunity to come to earth, which is our ‘second estate’ (Abraham 3:26).” (*LM*)

Because “of the Fall of Adam and Eve, we are in a fallen state in mortality (D&C 29:40)... From latter-day revelation we learn that the Fall is a necessary step in our eternal progress. Eve spoke of the blessings of the Fall: ‘Were it not for our transgression we never should have had seed, and never should have known good and evil, and the joy of our redemption, and the eternal life which God giveth unto all the obedient’ (Moses 5:11).” (*Lesson Manual*)

What are some of the purposes of mortal life?

How does your understanding of the purposes of mortality make a difference in your life?

• D&C 29:39; 2 Ne. 2:11-13. Why is Satan allowed to tempt us?

• D&C 58:27-28; 101:78; 2 Ne. 2:25-27. Why is agency an important part of the plan of salvation?

4. Life after death.

• Alma 34:34; 40:11-14. How will our works during mortality influence our life in the postmortal spirit world?

• D&C 137:7-9; 138:30-34; D&C 128:15. How can we help them receive all the blessings of the plan of salvation?

• Alma 11:42; D&C 88:14-16; 93:33.

“Through the Atonement of Jesus Christ, all people will be resurrected, or ‘raised from this temporal death.’ Our spirits will reunite with our bodies, and we will be able to ‘receive a fullness of joy.’” (*Lesson Manual*)

How can we be delivered from spiritual death? (See Alma 42:11-13, 15; Articles of Faith 1:3.)

After “we are resurrected, we will return to the presence of God to be judged according to our works (Alma 11:43-45; D&C 76:111). We will inherit a place in the celestial kingdom, the terrestrial kingdom, or the telestial kingdom based on the manner in which we have ‘received the testimony of Jesus’ (D&C 76:51; see also verses D&C 76:50, 79-82). (*LM*)

In what ways does the knowledge of life after death help us during mortality?

• Alma 12:32. How does a knowledge of the plan of redemption help when we receive commandments?

How can parents follow this teaching pattern with their children?

Next Week: Lesson 20: The Kingdoms of Glory; See L20 [Class Member Study Guide](#). † •

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).)

“Three Little Questions” John Bytheway tells a wonderful story about a missionary experience he had with an investigator who needed to know the answers to three simple questions.

†1. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “All men know that they must die. And it is important that we should understand the reasons and causes of our exposure to the vicissitudes of life and death, and the designs and purposes of God in our coming into the world, our sufferings here, and our departure hence. What is the object of our coming into existence, then dying and falling away, to be here no more? It is but reasonable to suppose that God would reveal something in reference to the matter, and it is a subject we ought to study more than any other. We ought to study it day and night, for the world is ignorant in reference to their true condition and relation. If we have any claim on our Heavenly Father for anything, it is for knowledge on this important subject.” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, 324)

†2. **President Boyd K. Packer:** “There are three parts to the plan. You are in the second or the middle part, the one in which you will be tested by temptation, by trials, perhaps by tragedy...

“Remember this! The line ‘And they all lived happily ever after’ is never written into the second act [of a play]. That line belongs in the *third* act, when the mysteries are solved and everything is put right...

“Until you have a broad perspective of the eternal nature of [the plan], you won’t make much sense out of the inequities of life. Some are born with so little and others with so much. Some are born in poverty, with handicaps, with pain, with suffering. Some experience premature death, even innocent children. There are the brutal, unforgiving forces of nature and the brutality of man to man. We have seen a lot of that recently.

“Do not suppose that God willfully causes that which, for his purposes, he permits. When you know the plan and the purpose of it all, even these things will manifest a loving Father in Heaven” (*The Play and the Plan* [satellite broadcast, 7 May 1995], 1-2).

†3. **President Henry B. Eyring:** “From time to time, I would ... give an overview of the plan of salvation. I would try to do it a little different each time. You could use different scriptures. You could emphasize different things, but always remembering that the point of it is more than intellectual. It’s not just to know who God the Father is and who Jesus Christ is and who the Holy Ghost is. It’s to feel *that* is reality and that those individuals—the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost—are real, that they know [us], and they love [us] and they are attentive to [us]” (in “[Teaching Our Children the Plan of Salvation](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 2001, 33).

†4. **President Boyd K. Packer:** “Individual doctrines of the gospel are not fully explained in one place in the scriptures, nor presented in order or sequence. They must be assembled from pieces here and there. They are sometimes found in large segments, but mostly they are in small bits scattered throughout the chapters and verses” (in “[Teaching Our Children the Plan of Salvation](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 2001, 33).

†5. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “Truly, of all the errors mortals could make, God’s plan of salvation is the wrong thing to be wrong about! No error could be more enormous or more everlasting in its consequences! No wonder this Church and its people go to such great lengths and expense to share the fullness of the gospel concerning this plan. No wonder the Lord wants this plan taught plainly and repetitively. And why not? It is God’s plan—not ours!” (“[The Great Plan of the Eternal God](#),” *Ensign*, May 1984, 22).

†6. **Elder M. Russell Ballard:** “We must give adequate attention to the doctrines of happiness—real happiness, infinite and eternal. They should be the objective of everything we teach in the Church and of everything we do” (“[Answers to Life’s Questions](#),” *Ensign*, May 1995, 24).

†7. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “So much more than a matter of abstract theology, this great plan can focus daily life. Its truths are crucial to how we see ourselves, others, life, the Lord, and even the universe. Or how we view a baby. Or death. Or the praise and honors of the world. This plan constitutes the mother lode of meaning and can cradle us, conceptually, amid any concern” (“[The Great Plan of the Eternal God](#),” *Ensign*, May 1984, 22).

Recommended Reading:

1. Robert England Lee, “[Teaching Our Children the Plan of Salvation](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 2001, 33.
2. Elder Neal A. Maxwell, “[The Great Plan of the Eternal God](#),” *Ensign*, May 1984, 22.
3. John Bytheway, “[Three Little Questions](#),” *New Era*, July 2006, 30-32.
4. Elder Richard G. Scott, “[The Joy of Living the Great Plan of Happiness](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1996, 73.
5. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[The Great Plan of Happiness](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1993, 72.
6. Elder Duane B. Gerrard, “[Flight Plan for Life](#),” *New Era*, Feb. 1999, 4.

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Enrichment Resources:

Elder L. Aldin Porter: “Each name emphasizes one aspect or another of the plan. But in reality there is only one plan called by many names through which God means to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man.

“Think of an airplane leaving the airport with the complete journey mapped out. The pilots and crew know where they are going, and they won’t get off course and fail to reach their destination once in 50,000 times, unless weather or mechanical troubles interfere. Now, imagine another airplane with a captain and crew but no flight plan. The engines are started, and the plane moves down the runway. Yet as it begins to climb, the crew doesn’t know whether to turn east or to turn west. If you are on that airplane, you will have almost no chance of arriving at your destination. It is clear to each of us that an airplane crew needs a flight plan.

“So it is with our lives. One cannot make wise long-range decisions unless one understands that there is purpose here and recognizes that he must understand at least some aspects of the merciful plan of the great Creator.

“The Lord has given us instructions and commandments to help us fulfill the destiny which He envisions for us. Commandments are best understood after one knows something of the plan. Alma taught this principle when he said, ‘Therefore God gave unto them commandments, *after having made known unto them the plan of redemption*, that they should not do evil, the penalty thereof being a second death, which was an everlasting death as to things pertaining unto righteousness; for on such the plan of redemption could have no power, for the works of justice could not be destroyed, according to the supreme goodness of God’ (Alma 12:32; emphasis added).

“A very important part of the plan is the right of personal choice. The Lord calls it moral agency. We may choose as we desire, but we may not avoid the consequences of our choices. Think on that. We are permitted to make our choices in life, but we ought not then call the plan unfair because we must accept the results of our choices.

“The center of the plan is the Lord Jesus Christ. Reject or ignore Him, and the great plan of happiness cannot function in your behalf. His life was dedicated in His premortal existence, through mortality, and even on into the eternal worlds to establishing the Father’s plan to our blessing and benefit. The cost to the Master was monumental. Think of the pain of Gethsemane and of His suffering on Calvary. This should give us some concept of the enormous importance of the plan of redemption. (“[Our Destiny](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1999, 65).

Elder L. Aldin Porter: “Pride, pursuing the vain things of the world, unchastity, misunderstanding gender roles, greed, and a disregard for the sacredness of human life are just a few of the obstacles in mortality. They can hinder us or prevent us from reaching our destination. The plan allows for repentance, but it does not allow for acceptance of self-destructive behavior.

“Many who design the philosophies of men know little or nothing of the purposes of God. Their secular concepts are often woefully inadequate for eternal purposes. If, for instance, one believes that man’s existence on earth is an accident of nature—one’s judgment will be flawed. These modern-day philosophers do not know of the premortal life of mankind, nor are they aware of the eternal destiny of man. How could they possibly build principles that will endure the tests of centuries?

“President Gordon B. Hinckley announced the proclamation on the family, saying: ‘With so much of sophistry that is passed off as truth, with so much of deception concerning standards and values, with so much of allurements and enticement to take on the slow stain of the world, we have felt to warn and forewarn. In furtherance of this we of the First Presidency and the Council of the Twelve Apostles now issue a proclamation to the Church and to the world as a declaration and reaffirmation of the standards, doctrines, and practices relative to the family which the prophets, seers, and revelators of this church have repeatedly stated throughout its history’ (“[Stand Strong against the Wiles of the World](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1995, 100).

“Some complain that when the prophets speak with clarity and firmness that they are taking our agency away. We are still free to choose. But we must accept the consequences of those decisions. The prophets do not take away our agency. They simply warn us of what the consequences of our choices will be. How foolish to fault the prophets for their warnings.

“Develop faith in the prophets and their admonitions. Seek the confirmation of the Spirit that they are inspired. Then when they speak and you respond positively to their counsel, you will find comfort, peace, and even joy” (“[Our Destiny](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1999, 65).

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Enrichment Resources:

Elder Gary J. Coleman: “Yet not all of those who learned of the Father’s plan in the premortal life, or who know of it in this life, are willing to partake of its joys. Perhaps this can be illustrated by the story of a group of United States Forest Service smoke chasers in training.

“Six men having been prepared for five days in the techniques of compass reading, woodsmanship, and fire control, were taken by truck to an isolated area. In the distance, some two miles off the road, they could see a plume of smoke, which they were directed to walk to as quickly and efficiently as possible by using the training methods taught during fire school. One after another, at fifteen-minute intervals, the men left the truck and set out on foot for the target smoke.

“The sixth man, drawing upon the training received from men of experience, quickly negotiated the course by keeping to higher and more open ground, avoiding steep canyons, thick brush, and rock slides. Always he kept his goal in focus. Along the route, he saw all five men who had left the truck before him facing difficulty with different obstacles. One, for example, was in the bottom of a deep canyon, while another was thrashing through heavy brush with his backpack catching on limbs and obstacles at every step, and yet another was slipping and struggling across a dangerous rock slide with little forward progress.

“The sixth man arrived at the smoke first. The fire-control officer was astonished to learn that the last man to leave for the objective was the first man to achieve the goal. After inquiring as to the whereabouts of the other five men, he was quick to award the sixth man the prized job of trail-crew boss.

“As this experience suggests, many will lose sight of the goal of eternal life with God and Jesus Christ. Others will fall into deep canyons of doubt or be caught in the brush and thickets of sin and temptations of life. Some will fail to follow the compass directions of the Holy Ghost, prophets, scriptures, and priesthood leaders. But spiritual safety lies in relying absolutely on the foreknowledge of God and the plan of life and salvation that he has provided for us” (“[O How Great the Plan of Our God!](#)” *Ensign*, Feb. 1996, 14).

Elder Dallin H. Oaks: “From such teachings we conclude that the Final Judgment is not just an evaluation of a sum total of good and evil acts—what we have *done*. It is an acknowledgment of the final effect of our acts and thoughts—what we have *become*. It is not enough for anyone just to go through the motions. The commandments, ordinances, and covenants of the gospel are not a list of deposits required to be made in some heavenly account. The gospel of Jesus Christ is a plan that shows us how to become what our Heavenly Father desires us to become.

“A parable illustrates this understanding. A wealthy father knew that if he were to bestow his wealth upon a child who had not yet developed the needed wisdom and stature, the inheritance would probably be wasted. The father said to his child:

“‘All that I have I desire to give you—not only my wealth, but also my position and standing among men. That which I *have* I can easily give you, but that which I *am* you must obtain for yourself. You will qualify for your inheritance by learning what I have learned and by living as I have lived. I will give you the laws and principles by which I have acquired my wisdom and stature. Follow my example, mastering as I have mastered, and you will become as I am, and all that I have will be yours.’”

“This parable parallels the pattern of heaven. The gospel of Jesus Christ promises the incomparable inheritance of eternal life, the fullness of the Father, and reveals the laws and principles by which it can be obtained.

“We qualify for eternal life through a process of *conversion*. As used here, this word of many meanings signifies not just a convincing but a profound change of nature...” (“[The Challenge to Become](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2000, 32-34).

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